



EMERGENCY department staffers work at Martin Luther King Jr. Community Hospital in Willowbrook. ROBERT GAUTHIER Los Angeles Times

MLK HOSPITAL TACKLES FUNDING CRISIS

With dire federal cuts coming, South L.A. facility seeks a bigger slice of county cash.

By Connor Sheets

Martin Luther King Jr. Community Hospital in Willowbrook is the main emergency medical care option for hundreds of thousands of South Los Angeles residents, but space is so tight that many patients are treated in large metal-frame tents on the pavement outside.

On a recent summer day, loud air conditioners blew cool air as nurses drew blood and tended wounds, calling to mind the makeshift spaces used during the early days of the COVID-19 pandemic.

The tents are a stark indication of the dire financial state of the hospital, whose leaders say it could be forced to close if it doesn't find a way to consistently bring in more money. The hospital recently reported \$14 million in net income for its most recent fiscal year, but operated in the red each of the three prior years.

Next year, it anticipates losing \$80 million to \$100 million in annual funding as a result of 2025's One Big Beautiful Bill Act, or HRI, which mandated changes to Medicaid eligibility and financing.

"One of the wealthiest cities in one of the wealthiest states in the country, in the wealthiest country in the world, in modern-day America, and we're caring for patients in four white tents on black concrete," Tony Weiss, MLK Community Healthcare's director of media relations, said during a tour of the hectic emergency department. "That's crazy."

As MLK hospital struggles against severe financial headwinds, its leaders are calling on the Los Angeles County Board of Supervisors to reevaluate how it awards the funds the county collects via Measure B, which levies a form of property tax. In fiscal year 2025, funds brought in via the measure totaled approximately \$427 million, according to the county.

The ballot initiative, which was approved by county voters in 2002, described "an annual special tax to raise revenue to support the Countywide System of Trauma Centers, Emergency Medical Services, and Bioterrorism Response."

Despite that, "ongoing" or recurring funds collected via the measure are allocated

[See Hospital, A9]

Gas smuggling fuels corruption in Mexico

It's the cartels' biggest revenue source after drugs

By Patrick J. McDonnell

MEXICO CITY — Mexico has been a major oil producer for more than a century, but its lack of refining capacity creates a quandary: The country must import much of its gasoline and diesel from the United States.

That's a boon for U.S. refineries and related industries on both sides of the border, but U.S. and Mexican authorities say Mexican cartels have infiltrated the commerce, creating a black-market bonanza in smuggled fuel while leaving behind a trail of homicide victims.

At its core, the crime known as *huachicol fiscal* is a vast tax evasion scheme centered on falsified paperwork — and corrupt officials.

Last year, Mexican authorities seized

millions of gallons of contraband fuel in scores of railroad cars and trucks near Mexico's border with Texas.

The follow-up investigation led to last month's stunning arrest of one of Mexico's most celebrated political figures — Ernesto Ruffo Appel, the former governor of Baja California.

The conservative Ruffo and his backers call him the victim of a political vendetta by Mexico's left-wing government. Prosecutors label him a central player in a complex, multibillion-dollar fuel-smuggling racket linked to cartels.

"It's false to say there is anything political here," President Claudia Sheinbaum told reporters in July. "This is an investi-

[See Mexico, A3]

Haitians in U.S. fear what's next after protections ended

By Maura Fox

SAN DIEGO — Emanuel Lexius' market in El Cajon is typically bustling.

Not lately. Lexius is Haitian, and so are most of the shoppers at Miche Caribbean Market. They come to stock up on familiar Haitian staples: Ti Malice vegetable oil spread, long-grain heirloom rice, Cola Couronne soda.

"People don't want to be out," he said, and "no one wants to be exposed."

A wave of fear swept Haitian American communities

in San Diego County and nationwide last week after the Trump administration revoked protections for Haitian immigrants living in the U.S. under temporary protected status, or TPS. The program has allowed roughly 350,000 Haitians — including thousands in San Diego and Los Angeles — to live and work in the U.S. because their home country is unsafe.

A federal district judge temporarily blocked the action for nearly five months before the Supreme Court upheld the Trump order in June. The Department of

Homeland Security officially moved to remove the protections July 27.

That has left Haitians in Southern California in a state of anxiety over whether and when they could be deported. Community leaders say the repercussions could be widespread, with people now scared to leave their homes or go to work — or at risk of losing their jobs because they no longer have work authorization.

"People who applied for a program that the U.S. government laid in place ... they

[See Haitians, A9]

'Orphaned' voters may be key in midterms

Californians without a candidate from their party on ballot could hold strategic sway.

By Kevin Rector

Esther Kim Varet has gotten a lot of questions recently from "depressed" liberals wondering whom they should vote for in November to represent them in the redrawn 40th Congressional District, which covers a large swath of inland Orange County and portions of San Bernardino and Riverside counties.

The Democratic art gallery owner placed third in last month's closely watched primary for the seat, behind Republican incumbent Reps. Ken Calvert of Corona and Young Kim of Anaheim Hills. Calvert and Kim were pushed into the same district by last year's Proposition 50 and will be the only candidates facing off for the seat in November.

Kim Varet said her supporters "obviously put a lot of thought into" which of the incumbents to support, but they have had a hard time swallowing the idea of voting for either. So she tells them why, "if we're playing a kind

of longer game," they should vote for Kim.

She says Calvert is favored to win, so supporting Kim will "force both sides to spend more on this race" and reduce Republican spending on other races where Democrats still have a shot at beating a GOP incumbent. She says Calvert is "much more senior" than Kim, so ousting him would be "more significant." And Calvert, as chair of the House Appropriations Subcommittee on Defense, has funded Trump's war in Iran and would be "morally the better target."

In the June primary, Kim Varet and other Democratic candidates collectively won 42.9% of the district vote, compared with Calvert's 34.9% and Kim's 20.6%. If enough of those Democratic voters coalesced behind Kim, they could end Calvert's 33-year run in Congress.

Whether they will, however, is unclear. Such "orphaned" voters — those left without a candidate of their party in a general election — are historically just as likely to abstain from voting or to vote based on far less strategic considerations. Californians created that dilemma more than a decade ago

[See Voters, A6]

Trump to profit off his policy posts

Investors can now buy early access to his social media, raising host of ethical issues.

By Bernard Condon and Brian Slodysko

NEW YORK — President Trump knows the world hangs on his every word. Now he wants you to pay for it.

The president's social media posts went on sale this weekend as his Truth Social business begins offering sneak peeks of them to Wall Street traders willing to pay up.

The move is just the latest to raise the prospect of big profits for Trump's company and big questions about insider trading and using the most powerful public office for private gain.

Similar fast-speed feeds are sold by other social media firms and media providers. But Truth Social doesn't just distribute the news, it makes it, regularly rattling markets as Trump

posts policy changes on everything from war to central bank leadership to tariffs.

"If this was the CEO of a public company, this would be jail time," said Irene Aldridge, head of Able Alpha Trading, which doesn't plan to buy the service. "We have a president of the United States who has the front seat to all the action, who makes all the decisions, and he's disclosing this ahead of time to a select group."

Trump's company responds

Asked about the propriety of the new service and whether White House lawyers had vetted it, Trump's press office declined to comment, referring questions to Truth Social's publicly traded parent. That company, Trump Media & Technology, issued a statement assailing critics — including business watchdog groups and other experts — as mischaracterizing the service "out of ideological opposition to free markets or a fail-

[See Trump, A9]

Voices BILL SHAIKIN COLUMNIST

Dodgers detractors, you could have gotten Skubal too



DAVID BERDING Getty Images

TARIK SKUBAL, formerly of Detroit, comes to the Dodgers for three prospects, none a first-rounder.

Your team could have done this. Is baseball headed for a lockout this winter? Yes.

Because the Dodgers traded for Tarik Skubal? No.

The Dodgers play a video before each home game, which includes these words from a sinister-sounding voice: "You need teams like us to point your finger and say, 'That's the bad guy.'"

In this case, "you" means the owners of the other 29 teams. You can hear them wailing now: Baseball is

rigged, and only a salary cap can unrig the sport. The Dodgers are the back-to-back champions, and they just picked up the best player on the trade market.

They. Have. Too. Much. Damn. Money.

But here's the thing: All the money the Dodgers lavish upon their major league roster isn't what made the trade for Skubal possible.

Oh, all that money helped put them in position to where Skubal could help them in October, but Skubal could have helped the Milwaukee Brewers or the

Chicago Cubs or the Tampa Bay Rays or the Atlanta Braves or the New York Yankees or the Philadelphia Phillies.

When the Detroit Tigers took bids for Skubal, they liked the Dodgers' offer the best. And here is what the Dodgers offered: three prospects, none a first-rounder, none ranked among baseball's top 20 prospects.

Outfielder Zyhir Hope was drafted in the 11th round, by the Cubs. When the Cubs needed a corner infielder, the Dodgers

[See Shaikin, A6]

STAR HOARDERS: Dodgers' Friedman got "aggressive" to get Skubal. SPORTS, D1

Gunman, worker dead in shooting

Suspect dies of a self-inflicted gunshot wound at In-N-Out Burger in Idaho. NATION, A5

Slur underscores banality of evil

Gustavo Arellano says Border Patrol's use of "tonk" degrades immigrants. CALIFORNIA, B1

Sparks rebuild with Plum trade

Team goes back to the drawing board months after declaring it was a contender. SPORTS, D6

Weather

Lots of sun; warm. L.A. Basin: 89/68. B6

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